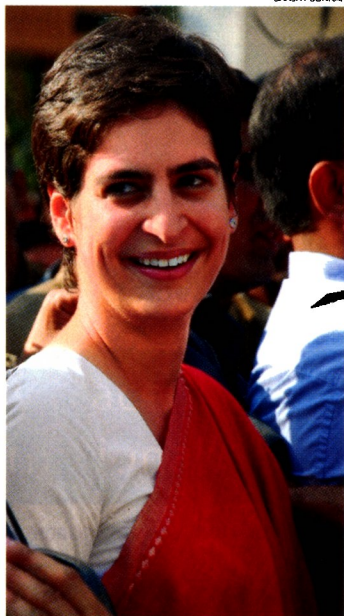


AP PHOTO



SANJAY SONKAR



THE GANDHI TROIKA OF SONIA, RAHUL AND PRIYANKA (ABOVE) ARE BATTING HARD FOR MANMOHAN

lier when he was questioned about matters beyond the Youth Congress (he is general secretary in charge of the youth organisations), he used to stall the questions with an "ask the Congress president". What has changed now is that Rahul has begun articulating decisions beyond his stated brief. The youngest of the nine general secretaries now does not hesitate to take questions on issues beyond the youth wings.

The party leadership has always given serious consideration to every word he speaks. It was his decision

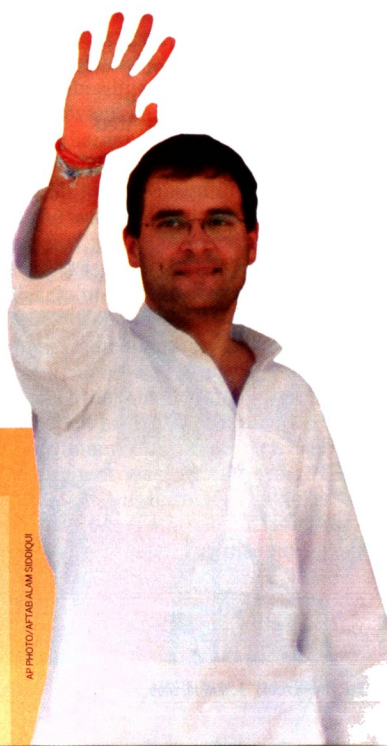
that the Congress should not contest the Lok Sabha polls under the UPA umbrella. As he is fond of saying, he is not playing a one-day match but is there for the long haul. He needs to build the organisation at the grassroots level even if the Congress loses out in these polls. This prompted a bitter Lalu to say sarcastically that while the rest of them were fighting an election, the young idealist was building the Congress. It was again Rahul who allowed party General Secretary Digvijay Singh to be a stumbling block in the

alliance with the SP. "Uttar Pradesh and Bihar used to be the heart of our strength and it is here we have declined considerably," he said at a media interaction recently and asked: "Did we leave Lalu and Paswan or did they leave us?" Technically, he may be right: it was the allies who ended the relationship. But it was the high-handed attitude of the Congress that pushed them to do so.

Again, it was keeping this organisational revamping in mind that Rahul came up with the naive suggestion of giving 30 per cent of tickets to the youth. He soon did a mid-course correction and admitted to his colleagues that perhaps it would be better to field the youth first in the assembly elections. However he stated that in non-winnable Lok Sabha seats, it might be better to field the youth! As a result, a very unhappy Karnataka youth leader and a Rahul protégé Krishna Byre Gowda was asked to

"If Rahul is praising Nitish for doing good work, then why is the Congress fielding candidates against the JD(U)?"

RAM VILAS PASWAN, LJP chief



AP PHOTO/ARTABALAM SODDUKE

inherited his father's blunt spontaneity and naive idealism in politics

RELUCTANT ENTRY

He too flirted with a professional career. Was working with a financial consultancy in London before being roped into politics to take over from his "mummy".

THE FIRST FEW STEPS

Became a first-time MP at 34. Like his dad, he too took charge of the youth wings as party general secretary. His spontaneous remarks often baffle his party.

THE AGENDA

Believes in Nehruvian socialism. Like his dad, wants to bridge the divide between India and Bharat by ensuring that the money meant for the poor actually reaches them.